

It is not necessary to specify these suffixes manually. When you export a *.XCF* (GIMP project) file to *.GIF* format, GIMP will show a dialogue box in which you can specify the settings for the layers *en masse* or globally.

Cartoon creation in Inkscape

For this article, I decided to create an animated cartoon of a jumping frog. The cartoon was created in Inkscape and assembled as a GIF in GIMP. The various stages in the creation of the frog in Inkscape are displayed in Figure 4.

In Inkscape, I selected all the shapes of the frog and made them part of a group (by selecting 'Object - Group' from the menu). This made it easier to duplicate the frog (*Ctrl+D*) and create different stages of the frog's movements. In each stage, I made changes to the frog's legs, using the 'Node' tool. The body of the frog (i.e., excluding the legs) was in a sub-group, which remained as a whole in all the stages and was not modified. However, its position and orientation to the legs was changed.

GIF assembly in GIMP

After all the stages were completed, I exported the Inkscape drawing to a PNG file. I then opened this PNG file in GIMP, cut the various stages of the jumping frog and placed them each in a separate layer. I added a vertical visual guide and aligned the frog's eye to it in each layer. This would create the illusion of the video camera following the moving frog. I saved the image to GIMP's native file format (*.xcf* extension).

To test the animation, I used the *Filters - Animation - Playback* menu option. The PNG image I



Figure 4: The frog cartoon was created in Inkscape



Figure 5: Several stages of the jumping frog were created in Inkscape and exported to PNG

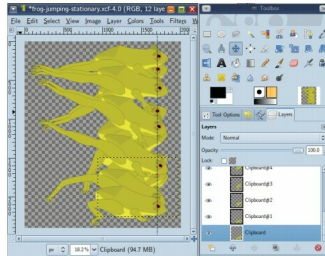


Figure 6: The frog stages were cut from the PNG file and assembled as separate layers in GIMP

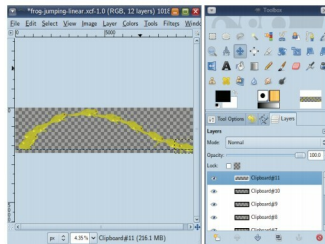


Figure 7: The layers were moved linearly

exported from Inkscape was a huge one. GIF files are usually small. Hence, I downscaled the XCF image (without saving the file) and exported that to GIF format. In the *Save/Export* dialogue box, I set the global frame disposal to 'Replace' and the

global frame interval to 100 milliseconds.

Getting creative with GIFs

I also created another GIF animation with the same layers. This time, I spread them out linearly so that it appeared like the frog was moving across the screen.

Then, midway in the layer stack, I introduced another frog. Hence, half the frames had two frogs. This made the animation appear like an endless stream of frogs. The final GIFs cannot be displayed in print, as they are animated. You can get them from www.vsubhash.com/osfy/gifs.

Stealing ideas from other GIFs

GIF does not need to be animated cartoons. GIF does not care what is in the frames. As you can see in Figure 2, GIF frames can contain screenshots or even photographs. However, remember that the GIF format uses a 256-colour palette and rich colours will be down-sampled. Still, GIF is a good option for Web graphics and non-interactive animations.

And, just as Web programmers use the hallowed *View Source* option to learn cool tricks from others, you can also open/download GIF files in GIMP and learn from the experts in the field. If you prefer to go that way, then be sure to change the colour mode 'Indexed' to 'RGB (View - Mode)'. If you forget to change this setting, then the image colours will appear like they are read-only. **END**

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